leaders giving up on building a “democratic Asian counterpoise to Red China.” And timing was crucial—if India did not progress economically as a democracy while Nehru was alive, a generation of “more Asia-for-Asian-minded” leaders would be more likely to follow an authoritarian path to keep up with China.

Officials, however, did not just highlight the dangers, but also the opportunity. They argued that the US and India were standing at “an open gate [rather] than at [a] crossroads.” India’s need for aid gave the US an opportunity. Delhi would likely see the US as a more attractive option to meet these needs for a few reasons: India’s changing view of the Soviet Union, which had lost some of its luster because of its October–November 1956 crackdown against Hungarian protesters; India’s desire to reduce its dependence on Britain and the Commonwealth; and India’s “uneasy political, social and economic rivalry with Red China.” The mission in Delhi even expected India to alter its external policies to facilitate its internal development—after all, “India’s foreign policy [was] to a large extent conditioned on India’s need and determination to progress economically as rapidly as possible.”[17]

Eisenhower expected the visiting prime minister’s primary aim to be smoothing the way for assistance. The president thought that the US should give India a “substantial” loan package in the $500 million range,[18] but Eisenhower heeded Dulles’s warning about making any concrete commitments.[19] Simultaneously, he did not want to appear to be “too cool.”[20] Thus, when they met in December 1956, he told Nehru that the US would give “every possible consideration” to an Indian request for assistance. This impressed Nehru, who noted that the president “seemed to be greatly interested” in India’s development plans.[21]

A few months before, in August, Nehru had detected a change for the better in the West’s attitude toward India. He traced it to the “feeling that with China having gone Communist, India offered some hope to stem the tide of Communism in Asia.”[22] Delhi welcomed American assistance. It had become even more critical because of the second five-year plan’s foreign exchange needs. Since the Second World War, India had received over half a billion dollars in food and economic assistance (in grants and loans) from the US. Now India needed more.